

Check Out

A Musical to Borrow

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CAST OF CHARACTERS

DEZ, an adult, Arbiter Library's passionate librarian

DEWEY, a young adult, the incoming intern who took the position because it was non-competitive

ANTONIA/ANTHONY **TONI** SEXTON, an adult, a tech leader and philanthropist who holds a childhood grudge against the library

Books**Sci-Fi Paperback, S Volume**

✿ Androgyny Library: Each character resembles the androgynous nature, with open-ended vocal requirements

✿ Queer People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of these library staff; cast accordingly

MUSICAL NUMBERS

1. "[Checking In](#)" Dez, Sci-Fi Paperback, S Volume, Books
2. "[Middle Middle Management](#)" Dewey
3. "[Pick Me](#)" Dez, Sci-Fi Paperback, S Volume, Books
4. "[Write My Name](#)" Toni
5. "[E is Everything](#)" Toni, Dez, Dewey
6. "[Check Out](#)" Dez, Dewey, Sci-Fi Paperback, S Volume, Books

INT. ARBITER LIBRARY - NEAR DISTANT FUTURE - DAY

It is the near distant future, yet things are backwards in the small town of Arbiter in the nation's heartland. Present in the library is the 2040 celebration aisle.

As daylight touches the shelf, the SCI-FI PAPERBACK falls off.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK
(Bloodcurdling)

Aaaaaaaahhhhhhhhhh!!!!!!

Beat.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK (CONT'D)

So, S Volume...? S Volume? Are you gonna check on me?

S VOLUME

Check on you? No one even wants to check a thing or two with you.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK
(Weeping)

BuT bUt We'Re UnDeR aTtAcK...

S VOLUME

This dream got you falling off shelves, it must be good. Science Fiction, *tell me your dream.*

SCI-FI PAPERBACK hops by S VOLUME.

INTRO (RECIT-Y, CAMPY PSEUDO-OPERATIC VIBE)

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

We were here on our shelf, going on about the library's funding problems--

S VOLUME

- as always.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

When we heard a loud explosion, and guess what showed up?

S VOLUME

Stalactite? ("stal" + "uhk" + "tyt")

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

A great green alien viking!

S VOLUME

Of course.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

He blasted our shelf with a ray gun! Then Dez
came in with a giant sword and-

DEZ, the longtime head librarian,
enters, fresh and eager for a new
day's work at the library.

1. "CHECKING IN"

DEZ

Hey you all.
JUST CHECKING IN...

BOOKS cheer.

DEZ (CONT'D)

(jaunty)

SMELL THAT DUST AND PRINT INK
BREATHE IN THAT CATALOG STINK
THRILL TO ANOTHER LIBRARY DAY...

S VOLUME AND SCI-FI PAPERBACK

HEY, HEY, HEY, HEY...

DEZ

SO WHAT IF THE FLOORS CREAK
SO WHAT IF THE WALLS LEAK
WE'RE HERE FOR THE PATRONS WHO COME ANYWAY...

S VOLUME & SCI-FI PAPERBACK

YAY YAY YAY YAY!

DEZ

Huh, the new intern is late. Yes, they are our
only applicant this year. These past few years.
We just have to make of what we have. Isn't
that why you are still here, on this shelf?

DEZ (CONT'D)

I CHECK IN TO WORK HERE
AND SMILE TO MY PALS NEAR
LET'S ALL CHECK IN FOR A LIBRARY DAY--

S VOLUME & SCI-FI PAPERBACK

--A LIBRARY DAY--

DEZ

--A LIBRARY DAY--

DEZ & BOOKS

--A LIBRARY DAY!

END OF "CHECKING IN"

DEWEY enters, looking at their
phone as though they were mapping.

DEWEY
May I check in?

S VOLUME & SCI-FI PAPERBACK
Check out the newcomer!

DEWEY
Who's talking?

DEZ
The books. It's always the books.

DEWEY
The books?

DEZ
Who else gives off words besides our own
mouths? You act as though you've never seen a
book in your life.

DEWEY
Twenty years ain't that long.

DEZ
You're kidding...?

DEWEY
I'm Dewey.

DEZ
Dewey. I'm Dez. Head librarian. The first thing
I ask you to do is to hold this book.

DEWEY
I don't know how it feels...

S VOLUME & SCI-FI PAPERBACK
To have responsibilities?

DEWEY
To hold a book...

DEZ
That's what this internship is for. We put a
book on hold the old fashion way.

DEWEY
Not that hold. But your hold.

DEZ
Wait. You've never touched a book before...?

DEZ reviews DEWEY's portfolio.

DEWEY

Well, I've always wanted to.

DEZ

451 area code...

DEWEY

It's actually 415. San Francisco.

DEZ

Do they not have paper books where you come from?

DEWEY

Everything is automated now.

DEZ

You should have applied elsewhere. You'd automatically fit in.

DEWEY

Your library is non-competitive. I put it as my safety choice cause at least my grandmama lives here. I do wish that Arbiter is by the harbor, but this town is in the middle of nowhere!

DEZ

That's the heartland for ya!

DEWEY

Ugh. I could've been with my college friends, interning in New York City or Seattle... They speak to me more than these piles of dust.

S VOLUME & SCI-FI PAPERBACK

Who you calling piles of dust?!

DEZ

If you don't want to become a librarian, what do you want to go into after college?

DEWEY

Middle management.

DEZ

Seriously?

DEWEY

But not upper middle management. And not lower middle management. Middle middle management.

DEZ

But why?

2. "MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGEMENT"

DEWEY

AT MY COLLEGE, I'VE BEEN TOLD
A JOB CAN BE HARD TO HOLD
THE CHANCE OF C-SUITE CHAIR IS PRETTY THIN
AND CURING CANCER? HAH, DON'T EVEN BEGIN!
BUT THERE'S ONE ROLE I KNOW THAT I CAN WIN
AND NOW, NEW FRIEND, I'M THRILLED TO LOOP YOU IN!

I WILL SUPERVISE THREE PEOPLE
OR MAYBE FOUR OR FIVE
I'LL GIVE OUT PRAISE LIKE STICKERS
TO HELP THEM ALL TO THRIVE
I'LL COMMENT ON A FLOW CHART
THEN LAY OUT WHO DOES WHAT PART -
OH, EVERYONE WILL LOVE OUR LITTLE HIVE!

I WILL BE MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGEMENT
WITH MIDDLE MANAGEMENT FLAIR
AND AS A MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGER
I'LL WEAR A WATCHFUL STARE
AND I'LL GET MIDDLE MANAGEMENT UPDATES
WITH A MIDDLE MANAGEMENT TAG.
I'LL GO TO MIDDLE MANAGEMENT CONFERENCES
GET MIDDLE MANAGEMENT SWAG!

I WILL CALL EACH OF MY TEAMMATES
EACH HOUR ON THE DOT
TO FIND OUT IF THEIR PROJECTS
HAVE PROGRESSED OR NOT.
I'LL UPDATE ALL THEIR SPREADSHEETS,
AND SCHEDULE DAILY POD MEETS -
I'LL BE THE GREATEST BOSS THEY'VE EVER GOT!

I WILL RULE MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGEMENT
WITH A MIDDLE MANAGEMENT SMILE.
AND AS A MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGER
I'LL OFFLOAD EVERY FILE!
I'LL GO TO MIDDLE MANAGEMENT OFFSITES
AND BUILD MIDDLE MANAGEMENT TOOLS
I'LL SOAK IN MIDDLE MANAGEMENT HOT TUBS
NEXT TO MIDDLE MANAGEMENT POOLS!

AND IF DARK DAYS ARRIVE WHEN I WONDER
WHAT IS MY LIFE FOR?
SHOULD I HAVE SPENT IT BUILDING TELESCOPES
SHOULD I HAVE JOINED THE PEACE CORPS?
(pause while DEWEY thinks)
I'LL TAKE A YOGA CLASS
THOSE BAD THOUGHTS WILL PASS,
AND I'LL RETURN TO WHERE I KNOW THAT I BELONG:

RIGHT BACK IN MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGEMENT,
WITH MIDDLE MANAGEMENT STYLE,
I'LL BE A MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGER,

I'LL GO THE EXTRA MILE!
WITH ROI, I'LL CIRCLE BACK,
PUT A PIN IN IT, AND YOU'LL SEE:
I'LL BE THE VERY MOST MIDDLE MANAGER,
THE WORLD'S MOST MOST MIDDLE MANAGER,
A MIDDLE MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGER, THAT'S ME!

END OF "MIDDLE MIDDLE MANAGEMENT"

DEZ

Well, take a chance and meet us in the middle.
Check out a book just this once. Take your pick-

3. "PICK ME"

S VOLUME & SCI-FI PAPERBACK

PICK ME! PICK ME! PICK ME! NO, PICK ME!

S VOLUME elbows SCI-FI PAPERBACK
out of the way.

S VOLUME

PICK ME, PICK ME, PICK ME!
I'M A SPRIGHTLY, STUNNING VOLUME TO SWIFTLY START.
READING ME WILL MAKE YOU A LOT MORE SMART.
YOU'LL SEARCH FOR SALTINE
YOU'LL END UP AT SARDINE
BUT YOU'LL HAVE TO CHECK OUT TO BEGIN!
SO IF YOU WANT TO READ ABOUT SALAD
AND THEN SALAMANDER
CHECK ME OUT AND GIVE ME A SPIN

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

PICK ME, PICK ME, PICK ME!
I'M A SCIENCE FICTION NOVEL WITH ATTITUDE
MY STORY'S FAST-MOVING AND WILL LEAVE YOU GLUED
YOU'LL FLY INTO SPACE
FOR A STARSHIP RACE
BUT YOU'LL HAVE TO READ ME NOW TO WIN!
SO IF YOU WANT AN EVIL ROBOT
WITH YOUR ALIEN,
CHECK ME OUT AND LET ME IN.

DEZ

AND PICK ME, PICK ME, PICK ME!
I'M A LONGTIME CATALOGUER WHO STACKS WITH EASE,
I'LL FIND ANY MAP OR MAGAZINE YOU PLEASE.
I'LL TEACH YOU HOW TO FILE
HOW TO OWN EVERY AISLE.
BUT YOU'LL HAVE TO DECIDE TO CHECK ON IN
SO IF YOU WANT TO FALL FOR THESE BOOKS
AND YOUR INTERNSHIP,
CHECK US OUT AND GIVE US A SPIN--

DEZ & BOOKS
CHECK US OUT AND LET US IN!

END OF "PICK ME"

DEWEY points at none of the BOOKS.
Instead, their finger lands on
TONI SEXTON, who barges in, self-
importantly.

TONI
Thank you for picking me.

DEWEY
And who are you?

TONI opens their mouth to speak.

DEZ
(Flatly)
Toni Sexton.

DEWEY
Toni Sexton! Shouldn't you be running your tech
empire? What are you doing in Arbiter?

TONI
Arbiter Township Library's newest board member!
Just bought my seat today! Now that there's
finally a new intern at my hometown library, I
can fulfill my childhood dream!

4. "WRITE MY NAME"

TONI
I LOVED TO VISIT THIS LIBRARY AS A CHILD
WITH A BACKPACK AND MY CARD AND A NEW SHARPIE.
I'D WRITE MY NAME IN MARKER, PEN, SPAGHETTI SAUCE--
TO RETURN A BOOK WITHOUT MY NAME WOULD BE A TRAGIC LOSS.
THE INTERN TORE MY CARD UP AND SUSPENDED ME.
THAT DAY I SWORE TO FIND A WAY
THAT I WOULD BE FREE--

-TO WRITE MY NAME ON EVERYTHING!
AND I WON'T STOP
'TIL IT'S ON TOP
OF EVERY PARK BENCH AND SWING!
I'LL WRITE MY NAME ALL OVER EVERY DAY
AND NO ONE WILL GET IN MY WAY

SO I GREW UP TO FOUND A TECH ENTERPRISE,
AND I NAMED IT TONI SEXTON INDUSTRIES:
MY NAME IN TEN FOOT LETTERS ABOVE OUR OFFICE DOOR.
IT'S EVEN ON THE TILES OF THE BATHROOM FLOOR.

WE'VE GOT A TONI SEXTON PHONE, A TONI SEXTON PC,
AND ALL BECAUSE THIS LIBRARY
INSPIRED ME—

—TO WRITE MY NAME ON EVERYTHING!
NO, I WON'T STOP
TIL IT'S ON TOP
OF EVERY PARK BENCH AND SWING!
I'LL WRITE MY NAME ALL OVER EVERY DAY
AND NO ONE WILL GET IN MY WAY

NOW I'M BACK TO WRITE MY NAME WHERE IT ALL BEGAN
TO FULFILL MY CHILDHOOD DREAM WITH A GROWN-UP PLAN
IN THE TONI SEXTON LIBRARY I WILL SMILE
TO SEE MY NAME IN EVERY BOOK AND OVER EVERY AISLE
I'LL SAVE THIS INSTITUTION WITH MY MONEY AND MY FAME
AND IN RETURN, I CAN FINALLY
GIVE IT MY NAME—

'CAUSE I CAN WRITE IT ON EVERYTHING
NO, I WON'T STOP
'TIL IT'S ON TOP
OF EVERY PARK BENCH AND SWING!
I'LL WRITE MY NAME ALL OVER EVERY DAY
AND NO ONE WILL GET IN MY WAY

I'LL WRITE MY NAME!

END OF "WRITE MY NAME"

TONI

And then, I'll fire the dastardly intern who
stole my library card!

DEWEY

You can't mean... Dez?

TONI

And what's this shrimp's name?

DEZ

Dewey. This year's intern.

TONI pulls out their phone and
types: "DEWEY." A section of the
library gets renamed "Dewey."

TONI

"Dewey" in a library seems appropriate.

DEZ

This tech is not the library I grew up in.

TONI

This is the library society needs to grow in.

DEZ

You'll never grow up.

The SCI-FI PAPERBACK catches
DEWEY's attention.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

Dewey... Growing up may be a science but
growing up perfectly is fiction.

DEWEY

What do know about me, you weird children's
book?

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

Not you. Your grandma.

DEWEY opens the book. The only
name in the checkout list
literally spells: "grandma."

DEWEY

Grandma's name is right here!

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

If grandma grew outta that childhood spirit,
you don't know who'd you be...

DEWEY considers reading the SCI-FI
PAPERBACK.

TONI

If you had let me be a kid, I would have grown
up.

5. "E IS FOR EVERYTHING"

DEZ

You were no kid. You've always been a monster.
Writing your name on everything was the worst
experience I've had here.

TONI

Boo hoo. You had to do such menial tasks when
you were an intern.

DEZ

Cleaning permanent markers ink was not my
profession.

TONI

It was unprofessional of you to suspend my library card.

DEZ

It's been a few decades. Move on.

TONI

Oh, I'm moving on into the future with ease.

TONI pushes a button. Everything is renamed: "Sexton."

TONI (CONT'D)

E IS FOR EVERYTHING
AND EVERYTHING IS MINE!
MY ELECTRONIC BOOKS WILL HAVE
A GIANT CUSTOM SIGN!

DEZ

E IS FOR EVERYTHING
WE HAVE THAT'S WORKING FINE!
OUR PRINTED, LOVELY BOOKS ARE WHAT
MAKE THIS HAVEN SHINE!

DEWEY shuts the SCI-FI PAPERBACK abruptly without a glimpse.

DEWEY

SO E MIGHT BE FOR EVERYTHING—
WHY SHOULD I EVEN CARE?
I'VE NEVER READ PRINT BOOKS BEFORE,
I SHOULD WALK RIGHT ON OUT THAT DOOR
RETURN TO SCREENS AND THEIR BLUE GLARE.

SO E MIGHT BE FOR EVERYTHING—
WHY DO I FIND I CARE?
THE FUMES OF INK AND DUST HAVE LIT
A SPARK IN ME THAT BURNS TO SPLIT
MY OLD LIFE PLAN FROM THIS NEW AIR.

THESE SHELVES SEEM SO FAMILIAR.
DID GRAN BRING ME AS A CHILD?
READ ME BOOKS ABOUT WHITE WIZARDS,
ABSENT HEROES, TALKING CLOUDS?
DID WE SIT ON THAT WORN STORY RUG?
END OUR TALES WITH A LAUGH AND A WARM HUG?
AND COULD I GET THAT BACK?
YES, COULD I GET THAT BACK?
AND DO GRANDMA AND HER FRIENDS ALL KNOW
TONI SEXTON WANTS THEIR BOOKS TO GO?

DEWEY opens the SCI-FI PAPERBACK slightly. It's as though they trust one another. DEWEY uses their ears.

DEWEY (CONT'D)

SO E -- E IS FOR EVERYTHING--
YES, YES, I FIND I CARE!
SO TONI THINKS HE'S SUPER FINE--
I'LL PUT HIS SELFISH VIEWS ONLINE
FOR ALL THE WORLD TO JUDGE AND SHARE,
TO JUDGE AND SHARE.

END OF "E IS FOR EVERYTHING"

TONI whips out a giant Sharpie and
nabs the nearest book. It's...

DEZ

No! That's a Shakespeare first folio edition...
1589. Is this the hill you wanna die on?!

TONI

Every hill in this land will have my name
written, too!

TONI and DEZ get in a tussle. It
ends with TONI triumphing but
getting a papercut.

TONI (CONT'D)

Ow, papercut...! It will have blood, they say:
blood will have blood!

TONI writes their name in blood.

DEWEY takes a photo of this
insanity and sends it out.

TONI's phone rings.

TONI'S PHONE

Ring, ring! You've got blood...

TONI

Oh the board! They're gonna put their foot down
in your termination, Dewey Dez!

TONI'S PHONE

...blood on your hands!

TONI

Hands?!

TONI picks up the phone.

TONI (CONT'D)

Your majesty board president- Uh... You got the
intern's email, what?

(MORE)

TONI (CONT'D)

You're rejecting my donation?! Health code violation?! It's Shakespeare. No one knows who he is without my name in blood! It's priceless!

DEWEY films this interaction and uploads this to the Arbiter community listserv.

DEZ looks at the DEWEY's phone.

DEZ

No... This is priceless.

TONI

What?

DEZ

The comments.

DEWEY

(Reading)

"Don't you dare touch my Shaky."

"To be or not to be. No one wants to be Toni Sexton today."

"Sexton thinks this is a Shakespearean comedy. This is a tragedy."

TONI

The tragedy here is this whole town! It's the middle of the 21st century and Arbiter is still so backwards.

DEWEY

Look, even a backwards town has listservs and Arbiter is no different!

Many of the updated electronics in Arbiter Library fail and combust.

Arbiter Library gets a sudden makeover by coders around the nation.

TONI

Don't unsexton the world!

DEZ

Wow. What possessed you?

DEWEY holds the Sci-Fi Paperback as DEZ reads from it.

DEZ (CONT'D)

(Reading)

Ah, the third act of humans beating the egotistical wealthy billionaire who hires twenty-something year olds to pillage social security. Absurd, but it works out.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK hops by S VOLUME.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

(Clears throat) *No one wants to check with me, huh?*

S VOLUME

Gotta hand it to ya, Sci-Fi. You got Arbiter Library out of a decades' long bind.

SCI-FI PAPERBACK

Science makes things work out, S Volume. Now...

S VOLUME & SCI-FI PAPERBACK

Let's spiral bind this deadbeat!

S VOLUME and SCI-FI PAPERBACK
chase out TONI.

DEZ

(Reading the phone)

It is priceless. Priceless.

DEWEY

Donations are streaming into the library's account! 2 dollars. 42 dollars. 451. All from the community!

DEZ dusts off a badge printer.

DEZ

We can afford to use the badge printer again! It may be against the core principle to label the library's content. But, we must put a name to the lovely people who make Arbiter Library and every library in the world come to life! You'll manage, being in the middle of it all.

DEZ pins a badge to DEWEY that reads: "Dewey, Arbiter Intern."

6. "CHECK OUT"

DEZ

So, Dewey. Are you ready to check in to your internship, and check out your first book?

S VOLUME AND SCI-FI PAPERBACK
PICK ME! PICK ME! PICK ME! PICK ME! PICK ME!

DEWEY
Well..

DEZ
SMELL THAT DUST AND PRINT INK?
BREATHE IN THAT CATALOG STINK?

DEWEY
YES! LET'S
THRILL TO ANOTHER LIBRARY DAY...

DEZ
LIBRARY DAY--

DEWEY
LIBRARY DAY--

DEZ, DEWEY, AND BOOKS
LIBRARY DAY!

DEWEY
All right, it's time. Science Fiction
Paperback, I choose you!

SCI-FI PAPERBACK
Yes!

S VOLUME
Scraping Scorpions!

DEWEY
Here we go...

DEZ checks out SCIENCE FICTION
PAPERBACK and hands it back to
DEWEY.

DEZ
LET'S ALL CHECK IN

DEZ, DEWEY, AND BOOKS
IT'S A LIBRARY DAY
A LIBRARY DAY
A LIBRARY DAY
A LIBRARY DAY

End of "CHECK OUT"

CHECKED OUT